

THE HUNTER GETS CAPTURED BY THE GAME: REPLY TO DAVID FRANK

Alfred C. Snider

*What's this old world coming to
Things just ain't the same
Any time the hunter gets captured by the game*

- Smokey Robinson & the Marvelettes, "The hunter gets captured by the game"

There is so much I disagree with in Frank's essay that I will have to be brief and direct in my response. I am reminded that it takes longer to identify a fallacy than to commit one.

First, Frank does not engage in a response, but rather frames a complaint. The logic displayed reminds me of a weak disadvantage one might hear in a debate (gaming is the dominant paradigm, there are serious problems in debate, and thus gaming is to blame). He pictures debate as isolated and solipsistic. This totally ignores the points I made about taking the game of debate to new audiences reaching out beyond the "elite" and "scholarly" as well as beyond the realm of rhetoricians, beyond the ivory tower, and beyond the realm of speech communication, through outreach, public debating, and debate across the curriculum.

Second, debate across the curriculum is the answer to many of the questions he asks. His demand for pedagogy is completely answered in my advocacy of taking the game of debate into every classroom, molding it to the needs of that classroom, and using it to activate learning in a new way. He complements the book I have written with Maxwell Schnurer, but does not realize how this answers his demand

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for a clear pedagogy. The game of debate is not a solipsistic endeavor, but a very empathic one. It is flexible enough to look at the needs of the situation and adapt to them. Debate as a method for studying a variety of subjects is not new, but Schnurer and I are the first to really outline the debate across the curriculum concept in detail. It is no coincidence that my vision of debate as a flexible learning game led me to propose to Schnurer that we write that book.

Third, while it is something of a compliment in some ways, I simply cannot be responsible for everything that takes place in modern debate. The syllogism seems far too simplistic. I am sure Frank would reject a similar syllogism about rhetoric (Frank is a rhetorician, rhetorical means were used to launch fascism, fascism is bad, rhetoric is bad, Frank is bad). Both arguments have the same weaknesses – alternate causalities, lack of demonstration of direct causal effects, and the understanding that any tool can be misused, among many others. To say that debate is in a sorry state and then blame my ideas is easy but inaccurate.

Fourth, Frank's points seem to represent the perspective of traditional rhetorical study and the Neo-Aristotelian scholar. Using the ideas of Aristotle in *The Rhetoric*, built upon by other classical authors, debate should be made to fit that mold and repeat its formulae. I have extensively criticized those who would make debate fit their "model" of discourse, whether it is policymaking, hypothesis testing, or Neo-Aristotelianism. All of these criticisms apply to Frank's efforts. He teaches rhetoric in a university classroom, and thus wants debate to follow that model in order to support what he feels is important. To me, this seems extremely solipsistic. He teaches traditional rhetoric and thus wants debate to mirror that as much as possible. Frank demands pedagogy, and he provides a very narrow one. He demands a relationship to established departments, and then identifies his as the only home suited for debate. It is up to the reader to decide who is more focused on the "self" if we are at all concerned about his charge of solipsism.

Fifth, Frank charges that gaming is trying to ignore the practice and teaching of argumentation. I disagree. Argumentation is all-pervasive in our lives and is totally at the forefront in almost any debate. One wonders what he means by "argumentation," and my assumption is that he means the classical approach. He complains that argumentation and debate have become intellectual backwaters

because “gaming” has divorced it from its natural home, thus depriving it of its support. Every student in every debate learns something about argumentation, even if it is not in the context of understanding the improperly distributed middle term of the syllogism. Rhetoric faces the same dilemma as education, as they are both reflexive concepts; they are methods without specific content (Schwartzman, 1997, p. 9). They are not fields of discrete knowledge in and of themselves and have to seek metaphors to give them meaning. Schwartzman argues that the metaphor of the game is the best way to conceive of the educational endeavor. The perception of both education and rhetoric from the perspective of a “game” gives us new and exciting possibilities for advancing both fields.

Sixth, I respectfully disagree with Frank’s assessment of the current state of educational debating in our world. While not specifically mentioned, Frank seems to focus on the ills of modern American policy debate. This ignores a critical point made in my original essay, that the game of debating is now jumping format boundaries with ease, with parliamentary debate, Lincoln-Douglas debate, Karl Popper debate, public debate, Ted Turner debate, debate across the curriculum, and many others. While I have only some hard data to support this, I nevertheless strongly believe that there is more educational debating going on now than at any time in human history. A huge variety of debate formats, a broad diversity of homes for educational debate (colleges, schools, clubs, communities), debating by groups not formerly involved (urban students, middle school students, home schooled students), and an international explosion of debate activity make this seem fairly obvious. The International Debate Education Association has over 60,000 students and 12,000 teachers in 27 member countries worldwide. (<http://idebate.org/info/description.asp>). The National Association of Urban Debate Leagues supports activities in 221 urban public high schools and 40 middle schools. Since 1997, more than 12,000 urban public school students have competed, and more than 700 urban educators have received professional development (<http://urbandebate.org/factsheet>). Declines in high school and college policy debate have been overcompensated for by the growth of parliamentary, Lincoln-Douglas, Ted Turner, and public debate formats. For the last two years I have been in charge of tabulation and pairing at the National

Forensic League national tournament, and it is clear that a huge amount of debate is taking place. This diversity of formats, participants, and venues proves my point--that the flexible game of debate can move beyond the supposed "solipsistic self" to adapt to different needs and different populations far better than a Neo-Aristotelian speech communication based activity could. As Schwartzman (1997) has indicated, games involve a proper balance between student autonomy and control necessary for education. If games are to be useful the rules and procedures must be flexible, and student voices must be considered on establishing those guidelines. Many countries do not have speech communications as a field of study, so the flexible game of debate can find a home, whereas the narrow vision Frank offers cannot. I am glad that the current model for debating is the flexible educational game, not the limited version offered by Frank.

Finally, there is the problem of "overtagging." This is a term used in policy debate when someone makes a huge and sweeping claim and then supports it with a quotation that is far weaker in its support for such a claim. Footnotes 2, and 3 and the reference to Randel *et al.* on page 36 are problems in this regard.

David Frank's hunt to link gaming to all of the problems of debate, as well as xenophobia and other horrific buzzwords, has disclosed that the flexible gaming approach to educational debate is either an actual or potential solution to these challenges. The hunter can get captured by the game.

References

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